minister doesn’t have my experience of the problems one faces on trains.’ He even reached out to Muslims. ‘Our Muslim brothers in Bihar are so backward. In Gujarat, one of the fastest developing regions is Muslim dominated. Let Hindus and Muslims come together and work towards ending poverty. Our religion is India first. We have to maintain peace and harmony at any cost.’

He spoke of Bihar as the land of Buddha and Mahavira. He even got a bit carried away (not for the first time) with the historical references, wrongly claiming that Alexander was defeated by Biharis, and Taxila was in Bihar (when it is actually in Pakistan). But these were only blips in what was clearly a virtuoso performance once again.

Significantly, not once did he refer to the blasts in his speech, only asking people to go home safely at the very end of his address. A few hours later, he visited the injured in the hospital and expressed his solidarity with the victims. I asked Modi later whether he had ever considered calling off the rally. ‘No, if we had called it off, there would have been an even bigger calamity,’ he insisted.

This direct contact with a vast crowd is precious to Modi. Whether yelling ‘Yes, we can’ in Hyderabad, or exhorting an Ahmedabad crowd with chants of ‘Vande Mataram’ or extracting a laugh through colourful attacks on the Gandhis, the moment of contact with the public, the seizing of mass attention, is Modi’s biggest prize, a legitimization of and a spur for his leadership.

That day in Patna was no different. Modi made a speech that revealed a development-driven agenda—not divisive but potentially unifying. He had refrained from falling into the obvious trap—a BJP leader could easily have played victim and used the occasion to raise the familiar spectre of ‘Islamic terrorism’ even without waiting for the investigation into the serial blasts to begin (much later, the Ranchi module of the Indian Mujahideen would emerge a prime suspect). Most importantly, he had shown strong ‘leadership’—staying calm and unflustered in the face of a major crisis unfolding around him.